

FIVE Stone Gardens

Japanese American Internment Camps, 1942–45

SHOJI NAGUMO has been called the “father of southern California gardeners.”¹ The first week of December 1941, he, Fujitaro Kubota, and Sam Fucuda were working as gardeners and landscapers in Los Angeles, Seattle, and San Francisco. Within two months they would be in assembly camps at the Santa Anita and Tanforan racetracks and Puyallup, Washington (also known as Camp Harmony). Six months later they and thousands of others would be “relocated” to internment camps in remote areas of the American west: Heart Mountain in northern Wyoming, Minidoka in southern Idaho, Manzanar in California’s Owens Valley, Tule Lake in northern California, Gila River and Poston in southern Arizona, Granada in southeast Colorado, Topaz in central Utah, and Rohwer and Jerome in Arkansas. Before and after the war they practiced their professions with skill, designing, building, and maintaining gardens and parks throughout the United States. During the war, involuntarily imprisoned by their government along with thousands of other Japanese Americans, they would, under the most difficult of circumstances, create great American gardens.

The Issei are first-generation Japanese immigrants; their American-born children are known as Nisei; their children, third-generation Americans, are Sansei; their children, Yonsei. Kibei were Nisei who were sent to school in Japan and then returned to the United States. In 1940 there were 126,947 “Japanese” on the mainland United States, most living on the West Coast; of these, 37 percent were Issei and 63 percent were Nisei. These people had been in the United States for

years, since the U.S. National Origins Act of 1924 limited immigration by Japanese citizens to a mere one hundred persons per year. All of the Nisei were American citizens, and many Issei would probably have become citizens if U.S. government policy didn't prohibit them from becoming naturalized. An additional 150,000 Japanese Americans were living in Hawaii, then a territory.

On February 19, 1942, President Franklin Delano Roosevelt signed Executive Order 9066, which authorized the establishment of military areas "from which any or all persons may be excluded." It was primarily directed at the 120,000 Japanese Americans living in a newly demarcated exclusion zone that included all of Oregon, California, western Washington, and southern Arizona. Given anywhere between six and twenty-one days to put their affairs in order, they were to be removed to undisclosed locations away from their homes and communities. The civilian exclusion order specified that they could take only "that which can be carried by the family of the individual." They sold their businesses, homes, and possessions for a fraction of their worth or they put them in the trust of friends or associates. Little of this would be recovered after the war. The displaced population included 17,000 under the age of ten, 2,000 over the age of sixty-five, and 1,000 handicapped or infirm individuals. By law, being one-sixteenth Japanese by blood was sufficient to be interned.²

The stated reasons for the relocation of Japanese Americans were military necessity and the likelihood that these "enemy aliens" would undertake actions subversive to the war effort. This rationale exposed the overt racism of the order, for neither German Americans nor Italian Americans were subject to the order. In a bizarre undermining of the rationale that Japanese Americans posed a subversive, military threat, those in Hawaii and the approximately seven thousand living in other parts of the country were not relocated.

These actions, in gross violation of constitutional protection and civil liberties, were contested by some at the time, but the nation had just entered World War II, and the Japanese American community had few allies. Only in 1982 did the U.S. Commission of Wartime Relocation and Internment of Civilians report, *Personal Justice Denied*, conclude that the underlying causes for internment were "race prejudice, war hysteria and a failure of political leadership." Six years later, the U.S. Civil Liberties Act offered a belated official apology from the government, along with reparations payments of \$20,000 to each surviving internee.



In response to Roosevelt's executive order, the federal War Relocation Authority (WRA) was formed. "Evacuees," the term preferred by the WRA, were to be sent to "relocation centers" or "internment camps."³ While these camps were being constructed, a hundred thousand Japanese Americans were rounded up and temporarily housed at seventeen hastily prepared assembly centers in Washington, Oregon, California, and Arizona, where they were to be confined and segregated from the general population. A former Civilian Conservation Corps work camp and two migrant worker camps were put into service, but most persons were sent to nine fairgrounds, two racetracks, a mill site, and an exposition center.

Most of these had been designed to house animals and had barely been prepared for human habitation. Stables and stalls were cleansed and converted to barracks, but the stench of animals remained. The evacuees scrounged lumber and materials and immediately went about the task of making the places livable. In the assembly centers the internees rapidly proved their mettle in transforming an inhospitable place into a habitable environment. Shocked and even bewildered by their incarceration and treatment by their government, the evacuated population responded in ways that brought to the fore fundamental aspects of cultural identity. An attitude of acceptance and resignation, of *Shikata ga nai*—"it cannot be helped"—was coupled with the trait of *Gaman*—"perseverance and fortitude." In each center they went about the task of self-organizing a community—complete with newspaper, church, hobby shows, dances, sports—as well as the physical transformation of the site. They took responsibility for cleaning and landscaping the grounds. They built ornamental gardens as well as victory gardens, the name that had been coined in World War I for home-front vegetable gardens that contributed to the war effort. A twenty-two-year-old agricultural student at the assembly camp in Stockton said that "we set right to work to make furniture and build a gravel walk. We even planted a victory garden."⁴ The irony of victory gardens for an interned population was dramatic. In addition, evacuees planted in full knowledge they might not be able to reap the fruits of their harvest before being uprooted again.

Many Issei had some agricultural experience. In the United States, racially exclusive laws and their limited knowledge of English restricted their occupational choices, so many Issei found it easier to



At Tanforan Assembly Center in June 1942, San Bruno, California. The original caption to Dorothea Lange's photograph read: "Mrs. Fujita and her neighbor inspecting the tiny vegetable garden she has planted in front of their barracks."

become employed in agriculture. The native-born and more acculturated Nisei had enjoyed expanded opportunities, but the agricultural tradition was well established. Many immigrant bachelors lived in boarding houses, known as gardeners' colleges, that acted as informal employment agencies and training grounds. The gardeners began to organize, and in 1937 three gardening associations joined forces to create the League of Southern California Japanese Gardeners. They had nine hundred members by 1940 when they began publication of the *Gardener's Monthly* or *Gadena no Tomo*. In 1934, a third of the Los Angeles Japanese American labor force were gardeners (1,500 out of 5,125). Many of these had been farmers, but discriminatory alien land laws drew many to work in the city. Forty-three percent of West Coast Japanese Americans were employed in agriculture and another 26 percent were in agriculture-related activities and business. They were farmers, truck farmers, nursery owners, flower farmers, and orchardists, as well as gardeners maintaining residential properties.

They operated greenhouses and flower shops and ran fruit stands. Before the war, the Japanese dominated the garden business on the West Coast, especially in southern California, the San Francisco Bay area, and Puget Sound. Their skill and industriousness was recognized by all, and there was even some prestige associated in employing a Japanese gardener.

Mine Okubo, a graduate student in fine arts at Berkeley, was interned along with almost eight thousand people for five and a half months at the Tanforan Assembly Center in San Bruno, California, a racetrack and stables. She was subsequently relocated to the Topaz camp in Utah. Okubo became a faculty member of the art school established at Tanforan by the internees and kept a sketchbook and journal in which she recorded her experiences. Okubo drew the victory gardens and noted that "great care and attention were given to them by the owners, who were spurred by competitive pride. The best were those of former truck gardeners and nurserymen." The skill of the camp's horticulturists, designers, and builders was apparent. The caption on one of her drawings reads: "A group of landscape architects decided to build a lake to beautify the camp. Trees and shrubs were dug up from various places and transplanted in the center field. . . . The workmen struggled day after day with limited equipment. For a long time we were kept in wonderment by this activity." She adds significantly, "everyone knew the camp was not a permanent one." Yet a few months later an entry marked the opening of North Lake: "It had been transformed from a mere wet spot in the Tanforan scenery into a miniature aquatic park, complete with bridge, promenade and islands. The lake was a great joy to the residents and presented new material for artists. In the morning sunlight and at sunset it added great beauty to the bleak barracks."⁵

Charles Kikuchi also kept a journal of his Tanforan experience before being sent to the Gila camp in Arizona four months later. His Tanforan journal entry on May 3, 1942, the day after his arrival, notes about the assembly camp's victory garden, "These industrious Japanese! They just don't seem to know how to take it easy — they've worked so hard all their lives that they just can't stand idleness — or waste." A month later he describes the garden the internees have created in the racetrack's infield, adding that he thinks the "whole thing looks like old Japan. Some people just can't divorce themselves from Japan and cling to the old traditions and ways. The garden is an outward indication of this sentiment for Japan. The odds are that the

builder of the garden is pro-Japan, although he may have built it for cultural reasons." In his journal Kikuchi, a student at the School of Social Welfare at Berkeley, perceptively ascribes political as well and cultural motives to Tanforan's garden makers. He is well aware of the symbolic messages gardens can convey.

By the end of July, Kikuchi recorded the internees' remarkable conversion in three months of a racetrack and stables into a domesticated space. Internees had transformed a "mud hole" into a level, graveled walk lit by streetlamps, which Kikuchi referred to as Grant Avenue, after the San Francisco street. He noted that "gardens have sprung up all over the place and the vegetables are now ready to eat." The internees had created sports fields and constructed a greenhouse to provide additional ways to keep active and productive. Kikuchi's journal also reveals his awareness of the internees' imprisonment: "Outside I can hear the swish of the cars as they go by down the highway. The barbed wire fence way below reminds us that we are on the inside. On the other side of the highway there is a huge glass hothouse where they raise chrysanthemums and dahlias. The tiny men working hard way in the distance look like ants, but they are free men."⁶

Evacuees would not enjoy their domestication of assembly camps for long, since the WRA was preparing more permanent relocation camps that aspired to be self-sufficient. The WRA's criteria for selecting sites were clear: they were to be far from population centers, a "safe distance" from military installations, but with railroad access and the potential for large-scale agriculture. Ten camps were built, all but two (in rural Arkansas) in the western American desert. (There were also additional Justice Department internment camps known as citizen isolation camps.) The eight desert camps were dusty, wind-blown sites, devoid of vegetation, unbearably hot in the summer, and frigid in the winter.

Political meaning momentarily put aside, internment camps did have a kinship with other forms of settlements. Each camp was laid out on a military model and at first glance looked like an army camp, but fences and guard towers revealed these as prison camps. As places built with great rapidity, they also fell into the American western tradition of "instant" cities.

Each site had climatic problems and challenges. Manzanar, Poston, and Gila River were in deserts. Minidoka, Heart Mountain, and

Granada had harsh, freezing winters and summer dust storms, as did Topaz, which was covered with greasewood brush. Rohwer and Jerome in Arkansas were in swampland. The internees were coming from the mild climate and environments of the West Coast. In addition to other hardships, they were thrust into alien terrain, as revealed by their first impressions. Jeanne Wakatsuki Houston, who was only seven when she entered Manzanar internment camp, recalled that "some old men left Los Angeles wearing Hawaiian shirts and Panama hats and stepped off the bus at an altitude of 4,000 feet, with nothing available but sagebrush and tarpaper to stop the April winds pouring down off the back side of the Sierras." A commercial artist's first impression of Manzanar "was the bareness of the land. I never saw anything like it. There wasn't a tree in sight, not even a blade of green grass. Coming from the northwest where there were a lot of green fields and forests, the sight staggered most of us. On top of that we had huge dust storms which made life miserable." Transferred from the Santa Anita Assembly Center to Granada (also known as Amache), Lili Sasaki recorded the dismay of the internees upon their arrival: "everybody was shocked because there was nothing but sand and sandstorms and tumbleweeds. Not a thing to see."⁷

The most common observation was of the camp's isolation and barrenness, and in places devoid of almost any vegetation, the omnipresent dust. Toyo Suyemoto recalled that, en route by train to Topaz, the "landscape became dreary, devoid of the greenery familiar on the West Coast. The Issei, who once had gardens or extensive farms, were faced with the sight of vast empty land where the sage grew and tumbleweeds rolled." As buses took them from the train station to Topaz, Yoshiko Uchida observed farmland, which was reassuring. However, the buses crossed into the Sevier Desert, and Uchida's heart sank: "All vegetation stopped. There were no trees or grass or growth of any kind, only clumps of dry skeletal greasewood. . . . The surroundings were now as bleak as a bleached bone." Arrivals at Heart Mountain encountered a similar landscape, and the first experience of some was of a blinding sandstorm. Of Poston, Lawrence Sasano said, "If you went to an area without any trees, totally barren and full of silt knee-high, and if you went into this all by yourself—it would be very discouraging, right? Well, this is the kind of environment they [the WRA] selected. This Poston is Indian reservation, but none of the Indians wanted it! Just barren, worse than desert, it's nothing but silt, knee high."⁸ Poston was at an elevation of



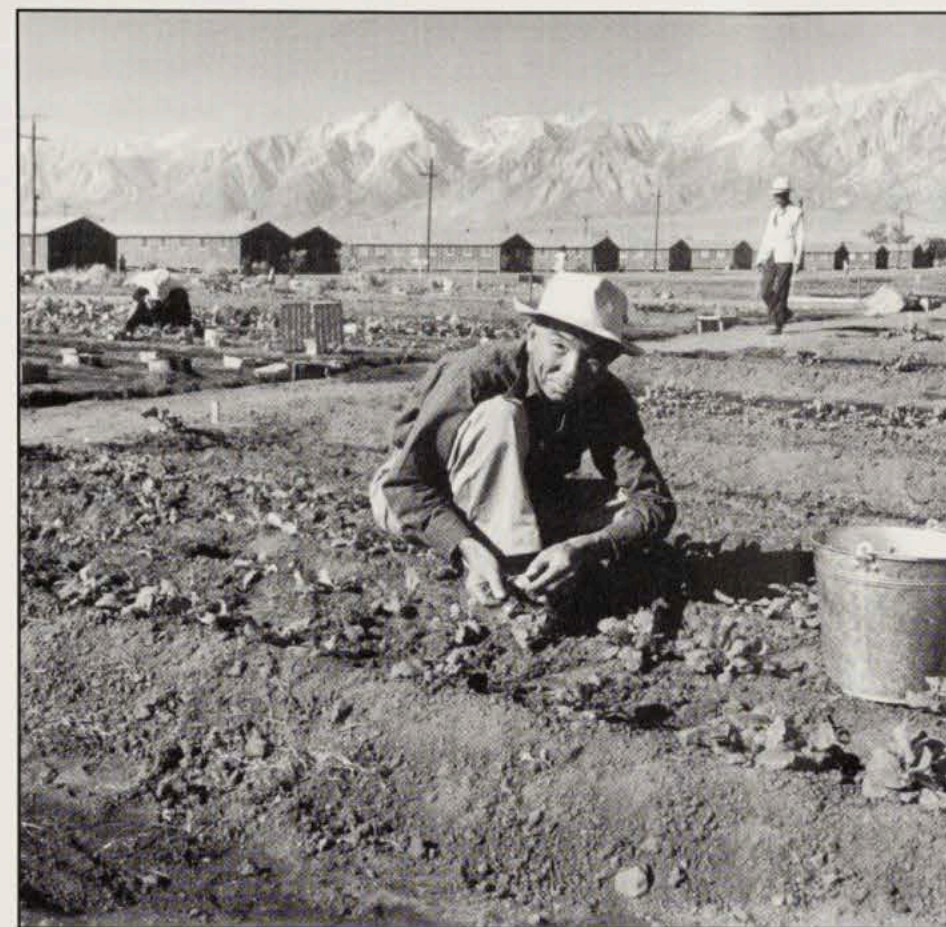
4,700 feet, had an annual average of eight inches of rainfall and averaged minus 30 degrees Fahrenheit in winter and over 100 degrees Fahrenheit in summer. At Topaz, Gila, and Poston, internees eventually dug cellars below the barracks to escape the worst heat of the day.

Isolated in sparsely populated areas, these were “semi-permanent new cities” with populations that ranged at their peak from 7,000 to almost 19,000. Poston and Gila became the third- and fourth-largest cities in Arizona, Manzanar the biggest city between Reno and Los Angeles, and Heart Mountain the third-largest city in Wyoming. At the conclusion of the war, the camps were dismantled and their residents dispersed, much as western lumber and mining camps had been. Many buildings were then reerected elsewhere. Ultimately the camps joined the western American legacy of ghost towns. They were to be rediscovered largely through the assertive actions of camp veterans in the Japanese American community. This finally led to their preservation as historic sites; Manzanar, for example, was designated a National Historic Site in 1992.

While each was distinct, the camps had been built by the WRA according to a set of prototypical plans. Guard towers were set along a fenced perimeter (Poston and Gila River were the exceptions), and inside the camp the basic layout was like an army camp. A grid of mostly unpaved roads divided the camp between blocks of wooden barracks separated by firebreaks. Each block had ten to fourteen barracks, with a mess hall, laundry, storage buildings, latrines, and recreation hall. The barracks were 20 by 100 or 120 feet and housed four families of four to six persons each; the families were often strangers to each other. Flimsy partitions merely suggested privacy.

Although residents described the camps as scorching, manmade hells, they nevertheless went to work yet again to transform these new inhospitable environments into something livable—anything to relieve the barrenness and tedium. Internees immediately went about the task of modifying their habitation, building partitions and furniture from whatever scrap lumber could be found. The residents modified the functions of the original WRA structures, converting buildings to fit their needs for worship, meeting rooms, classrooms, libraries, and other community services. By October 1942, half of the blocks at Manzanar had built Japanese *furo* (baths). Over time the internees built additional structures and facilities to meet the desires of the community: schools, churches, judo halls.

Spaces between the buildings were largely unassigned. There were



This photograph by Dorothea Lange shows the victory gardens at Manzanar in 1942.

large firebreaks between blocks, and some areas were designated as play areas on plans. Given the cramped and uncomfortable barracks, outdoor spaces were critical. At Manzanar Jeanne Wakatsuki Houston found that “once the weather warmed up, it was an out-of-doors life, where you only went ‘home’ at night, when you finally had to: 10,000 people on an endless promenade inside the square mile of barbed wire that was the wall around our city.”⁹

Internees transformed the camps at all scales, from the interiors of barracks to the landscape itself. They planted victory gardens in firebreaks and between barracks and constructed playgrounds and sports facilities for baseball, basketball, and volleyball. At Heart Mountain they diverted water from a canal to make a large earthen swimming pool. They built sidewalks, installed lighting systems, planted trees,



and created parks and gardens. The WRA had provided a raw framework for the energy and ingenuity of the inhabitants, who were domesticating an inhospitable environment. More was at stake, however. According to architectural historian Lynne Horiuchi, "The internees' building programs created community planning and new built environments as a means of defiance, less direct than political organizing, yet significant in transforming the conditions of their internment. By appropriating governance and building processes from the United States government administration, the internees created their own 'town' with their own town architects." The internees participated in a process of building and rebuilding, altering their barracks and camp design. A businessman from California scrounged leftover lumber to build a quintessential American front porch for his family's apartment "so that we could sit out there during the hot evenings." To complete the transformation, he later added a lawn.¹⁰

These small, instant towns mirrored, as if through a Japanese American prism, the picket-fenced Main Street American life that continued beyond their barbed-wire enclosure. Clubs and organizations were popular. The Boy and Girl Scouts were active, as were the YMCA, YWCA, and sports leagues. A nine-hole golf course of oiled sand was constructed at Manzanar. There were theater groups, dances, classes, and active hobby groups. Cultural continuity was sustained with classes and displays of judo, sumo, kendo, games of go, ikebana classes and competitions, and poetry contests. Buddhism was a spiritual refuge and a "repository of Japanese traditions," and individuals collected materials to rebuild the left-behind family altars (*butsudan*) honoring their ancestors.¹¹ Japanese language classes, however, were generally forbidden by the authorities.

The abundance of activities and the internees' transformation of spaces to accommodate them helped alleviate the oppressiveness and indignity of the situation. The population was accustomed to hard work, so idleness was a serious morale problem they promptly addressed by keeping busy; taking part in camp life was an important antidote. A male clerk from California working in a recreation program said he "felt happy in a way to find that I was responsible for contributing to something that was constructive."¹²

Many internees were sent to work outside the camps. At Topaz one man recalled the sense of freedom that accompanied getting out of the camp to work on a farm, adding that, on the drive to the farm "I filled my eyes with the sight of green lawns, individual homes, paved



streets, and actually water fountains. I never realized how much I missed those things that I had seen so often in San Francisco." For others, the energetic homemaking at the camps had the desired effect of improving spirits. Artist Kango Takamura at first found the mountains around Manzanar beautiful but the heat, wind, and sun oppressive, "but one year after, it's quite a change . . . a year after they built the camp and put water there, the green grows up. And mentally everyone is better. That's one year after."¹³

Arthur Kleinkopf, the superintendent of education at Minidoka, insightfully referred to the internees as "colonists," although one significant distinction between colonists and the internees was that the latter had not volunteered to be relocated. However, like colonists, they were engaged in an encounter with a strange territory, and they adapted their culture to these alien conditions and environments. In that sense the camps had an air of "New" Los Angeles, or "New" Seattle, much like the ethnic enclaves, the "Japantowns" — the *nihon-machi* — they had been uprooted from, but in the camps they were self-contained communities, with the larger culture located well beyond the fence lines.

The standard camp layout imposed by the WRA combined elements of military bases, prisons, and farm workers' housing. The plan had an implicit order, including the potential for an open-space system that went from the scale of a unit, the barracks as a multifamily housing, to the blocks, a collection of barracks, to a variety of community spaces. Like the military layout itself, there was an implied hierarchy of space, ranging from the social relations of the individual or family unit to the inhabitants of a block to the larger community. The internees were given an empty frame that they then modified and filled. This was largely on their own initiative, at times encouraged and even facilitated by the camp authorities.

Working within the static framework of the camp created by the WRA, internees created complete, open systems. They created community parks and gardens for families at the entries to their barracks, gardens and recreational spaces in the open spaces between barracks, community parks, and gardens at mess halls and in firebreaks. There were large communal victory gardens and the agricultural enterprises of orchards and fields. In addition there were the recreational

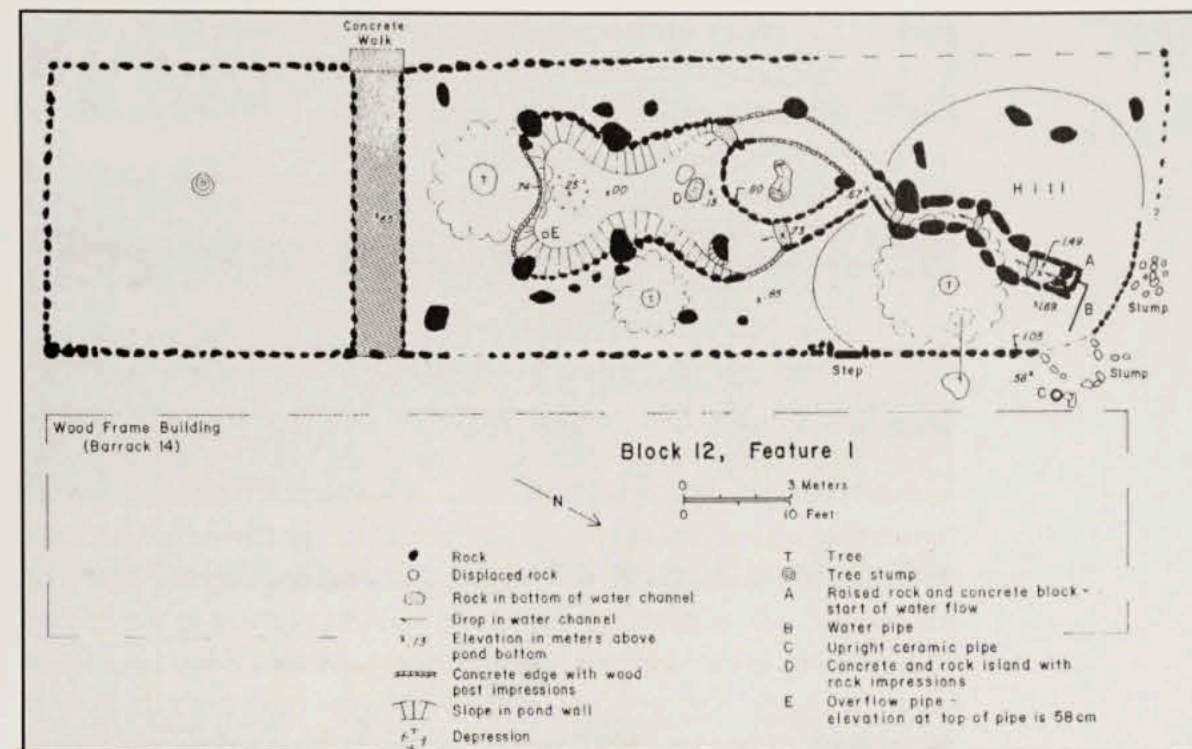


Children playing by the water channel in the pond and garden complex of Manzanar block 12, an oasis of greenery created in the desert.

spaces of fields, courses, and courts. Baseball was especially popular; Minidoka had nine diamonds, and at Gila River the field, designed by professional baseball player Kenichi Zenimura, had bleachers and dugouts and space for six thousand spectators. At Minidoka there was an ice-skating rink, and at Topaz, following a design by Moto Takahashi, the landscape department built a rink larger than a football field. Canals and irrigation ditches were diverted and excavated to create swimming pools. In some camps, spaces beyond the fences were eventually appropriated as gardens and picnic sites.

The camps had no private yards or fences to obscure activity, so the individual and collective actions of garden making were visible to both internees and the WRA. This garden making was also an open and sure sign of internees exerting control over their situation. Gardens became one of the symbols and signatures of the camps themselves and were pointed to with pride by both the Japanese American internees and the government authorities.

Each garden had a distinct function and appearance. The camps



Plan for the garden and pond at Manzanar block 12. The National Park Service has surveyed many of Manzanar's gardens.

were filled with graduates of gardeners' colleges, and their expertise soon came to the fore. Entry gardens were part of the Japanese tradition of dooryard gardens, linking household to community and function as entry and marker, displaying the craft and skill of the resident and embellishing both the barracks and the community space. Barracks gardens displayed great variety, using gathered cacti and rocks, transplanted plants, and plants propagated in the camp nursery. Water features were especially welcome in the arid landscapes. Ponds are essential in traditional Japanese design, but fountains were new elements, part of a still-evolving Japanese American design style. There was an imaginatively wide array of found and scrounged materials, including tin cans, pebbles, bottle caps, and glass. Many persons inscribed their names in cement at the doorstep. Henry Nishi referred to what the internees accomplished as "crude landscaping," but in fact it was often very sophisticated.¹⁴ While people waited daily for the communally served meals at the mess hall, they enjoyed the elaborate displays of great artistry and effort that characterized the mess-hall

gardens. Created with rocks and water as well as plants, these gardens were most closely identified with the Japanese American garden tradition. All these gardens brought beauty to the camps and reinforced the internees' sense of cultural identity.

One surviving example of a splendid garden is at block 12 (see illustration on page 167). There, the fifty-foot-long water garden incorporates a roughly hourglass-shaped pond. A small island divides the stream (B, lower right) into two channels, with a cascade on either side as the water enters the pond. The garden is carefully demarcated by a rectangular border of smaller stones.

In these desolate sites, finding and nurturing garden plants took effort. Some people brought plants they had cared for in the assembly camps, and additional seeds and plants were either mail-ordered or gathered locally. Gathering and transforming materials from the immediate and surrounding landscape marked a return to the origins of gardening, even where the natural landscape functioned as a nursery for the gathering of plants. In the WRA report on gardens, Robert Hosokawa observed the activity: "Bit by bit they brought home clumps of grass, mint plants, cattail, reeds and willows. Some found cactus, desert moss and bunchgrass. At first they placed these in bottles and brightened up their rooms. Few had gardens in mind but the materials increased and the idea grew. They carried home unusual formations of lava rock, dug gnarled gray sagebrush to plant as shrubbery along their porches. Children cornered little fish in the shallows of the canal and found rocklike mussels buried in soft silt."¹⁵ As the plant population increased, internees also established camp nurseries to expand seed and plant propagation.

Camp authorities encouraged these activities, as a statement by E. R. Fryer, the regional director of the WRA, reprinted in the *Gila News-Courier*, reveals: "To all of you who live here, I want to give special encouragement in the transplanting of native shrubs and plants around your homes and in the creation of small rock gardens. Many of you brought plants and seeds with you which can also be used. Until irrigation water becomes available, it will be necessary, of course, to plan improvement requiring a small amount of water. I shall watch this program for the improvement of grounds and the beautification of homes with special interest. Later, I hope we can find some way to give special recognition to those whose creations are outstanding."¹⁶

Eventually, authorities even permitted short, unescorted expeditions outside camp to gather materials, especially stones. Frank

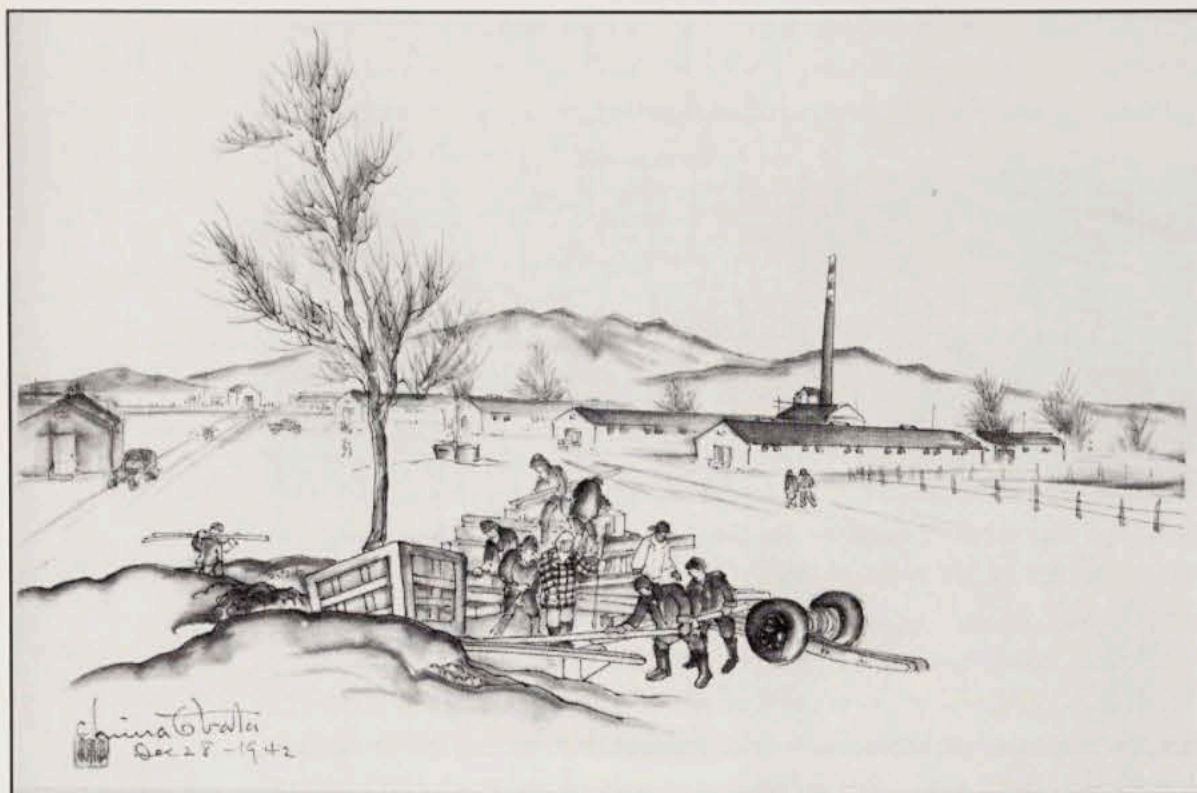


Note the "bonsaied" sagebrush and the Tori gate leading to the park at the northern edge of Minidoka camp.

Kadowaki, an artist who had worked as a farmer at the Irvine Ranch, remembered: "I worked on a Japanese garden for the administration. They gave us a truck and permission to go out and pick up rocks. We'd drive out fifty to seventy-five miles away from camp to bring back rocks — oh, we feel paradise!" These activities merely continued an established prewar garden practice; Arthur Ogami, for example, recalled trips he would make with his father into the hills to find rocks for his garden.¹⁷

Gathering brought features of the surrounding landscape into the camp and, by removing things from the wild area outside the camp, it also mildly domesticated that landscape. Found stones became the raw materials for compositions complex in structure and symbolism. They were essential in defining garden spaces and demarcating the functional relationships between walkways, barracks, and gardens. Gathering vegetation involved more than simply transplanting: plants were uprooted, replanted, rearranged, and pruned. Sometimes they were left in place but remade. In a powerful image of the cultural transformation of a wild inhospitable place, at the "Wildlife Preserve" in Minidoka Mr. Nitta "bonsaied" the sagebrush in place. His action domesticated the wild plants, made the wild into a garden, and also made it "Japanese."

Agricultural self-sufficiency for each camp was a government objective, and since many internees were in fact skilled and energetic



Chiura Obata's drawing of transplanting trees from the mountains for Topaz, December 1942.

farmers, work toward this goal progressed rapidly. They established seed farms, nurseries, a lath house, and greenhouses, and constructed canals, irrigation ditches, and reservoirs. At Gila River over 1,600 acres were cultivated, and internees redirected effluent from the sewage treatment plant to irrigate a ten-acre farm. At Granada high-school students operated a 500-acre farm. In 1943 Manzanar's farms produced over 42,000 tons of produce. Minidoka's most famous surviving feature is an enormous root cellar.

Despite the commonalities resulting from all the camps being constructed and run by the WRA, the condition and location of each camp was unique. Gila, Manzanar, and Topaz had soils that were amenable to agriculture and gardening. The climate at Heart Mountain was especially harsh, with a growing season of 119 days, but internees nevertheless planted victory gardens and built greenhouses to grow seedlings for the farm. Estelle Ishigo wrote in her memoir that her grandmother ordered seed from a catalog, wanting "to nurse

little growing things in her room . . . just once again to see the beauty of young, living plants."¹⁸

Topaz internees undertook a massive effort to plant over 7,500 trees and 10,000 shrubs in the first year. Uchida described the first Thanksgiving at Topaz:

The men of our block had spent the entire day planting willow saplings that had been transported into camp from somewhere beyond the desert. The young trees looked too frail to survive in the alkaline soil, but we all felt anything was worth trying. We longed desperately for something green, some trees or shrubs or plants so we might have something to look forward to with the approach of spring. There existed a master plan that called for the planting of one large tree in front of every mess hall and the lining of the two-hundred-foot wide firebreaks between each block with trees as well. It was a nice thought, and efforts to make it a reality got under way in December.

However, most of the 17,500 trees and shrubs succumbed to the desert: "our desert remained a desert, and not even the industrious Japanese Americans could transform it into anything else."¹⁹

These labors continued, capitalizing on the internees' expertise, and were regularly reported in the camp newspaper, the *Topaz Times*. The city's staff of three landscape architects, including Berkeley graduates Tom Takaki and Don Akamatsu, created and implemented an impressively comprehensive beautification plan under the supervision of Roscoe Bell, chief of the agricultural division. Plans included a mini-park with each housing block, but the plans also specifically gave the residents freedom to participate or individualize these semipublic spaces, noting that "the final appearance of the City will depend largely upon the amount of effort the residents are willing to expend for beautification."²⁰ It also included plans for athletic fields for baseball, softball, football, tennis courts, and even a nine-hole golf course designed by G. Matsuma, an experienced golf course landscaper. They also addressed plans for walks and paths as well as service areas.

There was also a focus on the civic structure of the camp. Takaki and Nobuo Kawabata, chief foremen of the landscape and gardening section, developed plans for Topaz Plaza, an area between the hospital and administration buildings. A ten-acre nursery under the direction of H. Hayashi and S. Neishi, veteran nurserymen of Oakland, was also established. Mass plantings attempted to ameliorate the dusty and hot conditions as well as beautify the camp.

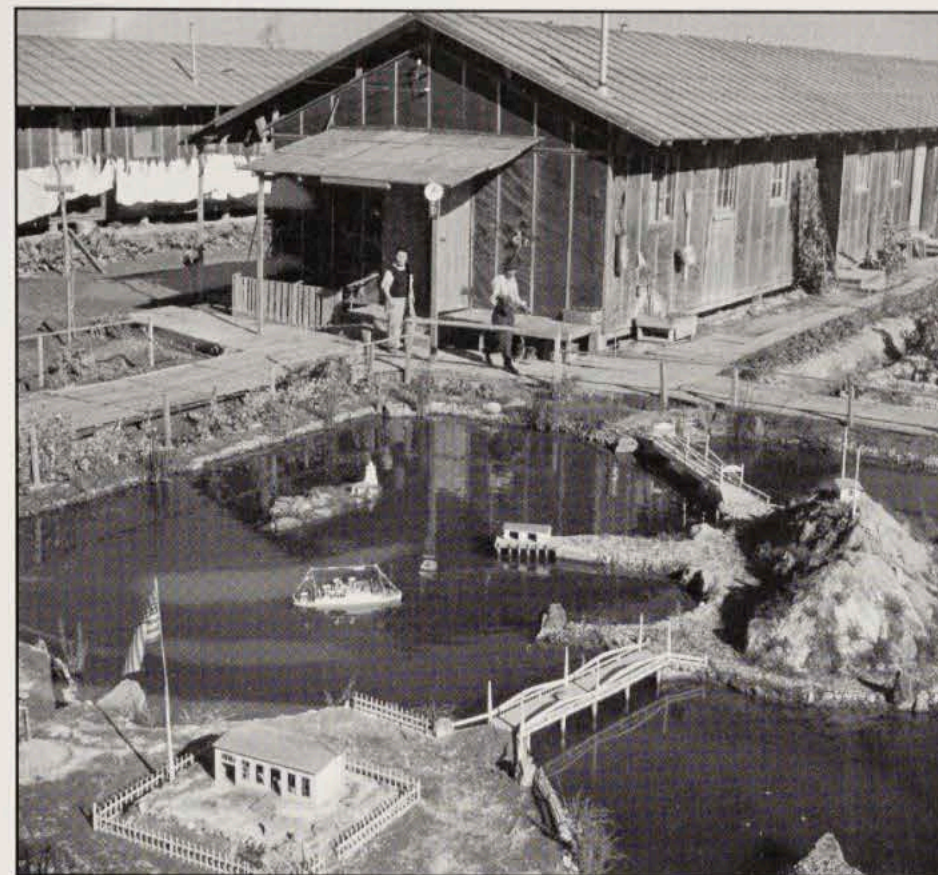


The original caption of Mine Okubo's drawing read: "In November, Arbor Day was celebrated by the distribution of small shrubs to each block. There was an overnight change in camp scenery. Trees and shrubs appeared in the most unexpected places."

Hundreds of willow and tamarisks, which bloom in late summer, were planted. In the spring of 1943, over two thousand shrubs were shipped from Logan, Utah, for camp landscaping. A picnic area with barbecue pits, tables, and benches was located in a grove of poplar trees.

Mine Okubo's journal recorded these activities. Her sketches of the camp appeared in the *San Francisco Chronicle* along with quotes from Dillon Meyer, the head of the WRA. A rare humorous drawing shows a person tripping over a newly planted tree. She noted the imaginative use of makeshift materials, as windscreens were erected and evening bucket brigades carried water from the laundry to the gardens. In the spring she noted with surprise that, despite the conditions, "green began to appear in the trees and shrubs, especially on those planted near washrooms." The struggle to grow anything at Topaz was constant. Yet despite the setbacks, Uchida observed that the "people of Topaz never gave up in their efforts to improve the camp."²¹

At Granada in eastern Colorado, Atsushi Kikuchi reports that they referred to the place as a sand bowl; when windy, "the whole place filled up with dust. It was almost like a fog." Despite the inhospitable conditions, internees transplanted trees from the nearby riverbank, constructed barracks, and created victory gardens. By the time Kikuchi left, he noted that the camp "was quite green." Wataru Ishisaka remembered "flowers that resembled morning glories. They were a lot bigger than morning glories and really beautiful. The roots



The pond at Poston 1 incorporated bridges and an island populated with miniature buildings.

were very big, like potatoes. They said that the Indians used to make wine out of these roots. Digging the roots of the plants became very popular with the Issei."²²

George Sogioka thought Poston must be the worst camp, yet he said with pride that "we built the whole thing. We grew everything — vegetables and all this and that . . . the Japanese are farmers, they grow everything in the desert."²³ Gathering was critical at Poston: Lawrence Sasano transplanted cactus from the desert, including one fourteen-foot-tall specimen for his garden. Mr. Sato, who met his future wife at Poston, captured carp from the Colorado River to put in the fish gardens his family built near their barracks.

Poston's ambitious internees also built three swimming pools along irrigation ditches that ran through the firebreaks. Men cleared a rare shaded area full of brush. One resident noted that it began to take on the appearance of a park with benches and tables. At the request of



Two girls posing in front of their barracks at Tule Lake, northern California.

the camp administration, the sculptor Isamu Noguchi, who was chair of the landscape and park areas, drew plans for parks, recreation areas, and a cemetery, but these were not realized.

Gila River's landscape engineering department employed forty men; it also had a grounds department. Gila residents had already set aside ten acres for community gardens, planted dozens of trees, and beautified barracks when Roy Marubayashi, under the supervision of the landscape engineer Ellsworth Nichols, was asked to develop a general landscape plan for the camp. The departments also landscaped the grounds of the school, the administration buildings, and the hospitals, incorporating citrus trees, palms, and Italian cypress brought from Mesa, Arizona. Marubayashi also drew plans for each residential block, taking into account the efforts already made by individuals. In most issues, the *Gila-News Courier* made a point of praising the individual efforts and "artistic touches" of people like Y. Tomita and Sam Fukuda.

After visiting the Gila River camp in 1943, Eleanor Roosevelt wrote "To Undo a Mistake Is Always Harder than Not to Create One Originally" for *Collier's* magazine. The first lady observed that WRA



Henry Sugimoto's painting *Planting Vegetables* in Rohwer, Arkansas.

contractors had leveled the land completely, removing even scrub growth. She commended the internees for their beautification and domestication efforts: "Around the barracks buildings at Gila, a great effort has been made to ameliorate this condition by using scrap lumber and burlap bags for makeshift porches and awnings. They are now getting screens for protection against the insects. They have made small gardens, some with vegetables and some flowers and shrubs from the surrounding desert, to beautify the barren streets."²⁴ Ponds, many whimsically shaped, were commonplace at Gila River. Many were constructed partially under the barracks, for cooling, to shelter fish from the sun, or as part of the garden aesthetic.

The natural environment at the Arkansas camps was more amenable to garden creation. At Rohwer, for example, virtually every barracks had a garden, and the camp developed a lushness as tarpaper shacks receded behind the screen of vegetation. Jerome resident Sada Murayama remembered "a trellis with morning glories, forming a tunnel of flowers," and that visitors to the camp were often taken to view a "showplace" block.²⁵

Surviving information of garden creation is most abundant for



This photograph of block 5 at Rohwer reveals the differences between the Arkansas camps and the desert camps.

Minidoka and Manzanar, the two sites that have been the subjects of extensive research by the National Park Service.

Minidoka Interlude, a yearbook of the camp from September 1942 to October 1943, includes group photographs of residents posed in front of their barracks in the camp in Hunt, Idaho. Most pictures show newly planted trees. Many blocks were individualized with entry gardens at every doorway, vines trained on the ends of barracks, group vegetable gardens, or stands of sunflowers. The camp's co-op stores included a flower shop, and several pages from *Minidoka Interlude* were dedicated to the victory gardens that the children took care of.

A 1943 report of the gardens at Minidoka is part of the record for the camp. "Along the streets of the Minidoka Relocation Center at random intervals are little gardens, bits of neat landscaping by patient and artistic Japanese. A few weeks ago the newly-built barracks were severe and ugly. The dust was deep around each crude porch and it swirled like smoke when the wind swept through Minidoka." The

author, internee Robert Hosokawa, observed the relationship between where people came from and the place they encountered:

The people who moved into these homes were from green hillsides and valleys of the coast. They had lived with tree[s] and flowers and broad fields of green truck. City people had their lawns and gardens; some little plot to nurse. Even those who lived in yardless downtown hotels kept tiny window boxes filled with geraniums and morning glories. Minidoka was desiccated, drab and dusty. But life is not worth living for these people unless they have something green to cultivate. A few brought with them from assembly centers pots of vines or ferns. Most of those withered on the train. Tenderly they watered these after reaching Minidoka to restore their greenness. Some planted radishes and onions as soon as they watered down the dust.

The report also details examples of garden creation:

So it was that Yoshio Hamamoto, resident of Block 2 and an employee of the hospital, created a garden. He made a pond of rocks and secured enough cement from the dust where a pile of sacks had stood to line the bottom and sides. He planted bits of grass and moss to border the pond. Then with fish from the canal, pieces of water grass, some mussels and a frog his garden was complete. It adds much to his home and to his leisure moments. Seven bachelors living together at 2-4-E walked into the desert every day. It was not long before they had gathered 60 little sagebrush trees, chosen for their rugged beauty. Patiently they trimmed the stunted trees, wired twigs and replanted them in three neat rows fronting their barrack. These suggest and often closely resemble the dwarfed pines characteristic in Japanese art.²⁶

The WRA superintendent of education at Minidoka, Arthur Kleinkopf, kept a work diary from 1942 to 1946. His entries are filled with numerous garden references from their inception and the marshaling of materials through harvests. He observed that "evacuees certainly take great pride in beautifying the homes." Between barracks, lawns began to appear — the signature element of the American residential garden. Kleinkopf noted that these provided places for children to play and adults to rest. Several hundred acres were given over to victory gardens. The camp's agriculture club even drew up plans for the "ideal vegetable garden."²⁷

Kleinkopf, an educator, paid careful attention to the school garden and farm program. In June 1943 he was pleased that "school garden-

ing is certainly being emphasized now. Each grade has a plot to seed and cultivate." He notes that "many of the pupils and the teachers have much to learn about gardening. One student teacher asked Mr. Briggs for the potato plants and was much surprised to learn that one planted a potato and not a plant. In one row I noticed watermelon and corn being planted in the same hill." He finds fifth- and sixth-grade boys carrying water from the laundry room instead of the irrigation ditch. They said that they were doing that because "they didn't think that muddy water would be good for the garden."²⁸ In July Kleinkopf wrote with pride that the first peas from the gardens were served at the mess hall. In addition to the smaller school gardens, there was an experimental farm of fifty acres for the high school as well as a 300-plus-acre farm to sustain the camp.

Work to beautify the camp also continued unabated. A March 1944 entry in Kleinkopf's diary describes efforts to beautify the area between blocks 16 and 17, which was to be made into a "natural" picnic area:

Mr. Nitta, a Japanese gardener, has volunteered his services to do some landscaping here. He has landscaped a large area of sagebrush by removing all the small scrubby brush, leaving the large ones standing, and has planted flowers here and there in the area. He has also constructed windbreak walls of lava rock and out of old junk material has made camping stoves. One could never imagine a sagebrush area being made into a picnic ground, but this one really looks beautiful. Residents and particularly the school children are invited to come on picnics. Near this sagebrush park there are many gardens of flowers and vegetables. Water for this is carried from the nearby irrigation canal. Footbridges with banisters and overhead decorations adorn the place. It is one of the bright spots of the entire camp.²⁹

Over time, internees developed an appreciation and even a sense of stewardship for the distinctive aspects of the southern Idaho landscape. The *Minidoka Irrigator* reported on the making of an area just beyond the fence designated "for the preservation of wild plant life" under the supervision of C. Natsuhara. The article also quoted C. Misuki's disappointment at the abuse of wild plants by careless residents. "This is not right. We must practice more care in the future or wild life will disappear altogether," he stated. This concern for conservation echoed the sentiments from Gila, where an editorial titled "Cactus Cutters Cautioned" in the camp newspaper urged that "when

the days of peace come again and we leave here let us leave these cactus plants as they are today — standing in all their splendor and not dead . . . rotted things on the ground."³⁰

A 1943 *Minidoka Irrigator* editorial observed how conditions at the camp fostered an appreciation and awareness of nature. "We hadn't learned to appreciate the good that comes with Nature — until Minidoka. Then the 'beautiful, silvery sage' became a standing joke. Dust and mud became part of the furniture. People learned to wince when they saw a blade of grass uprooted. A struggling green shoot became a dear thing to be coddled and petted. Wistful groups took to gazing longingly at the trees faintly visible beyond the miles on end of sagebrush."³¹

Minidoka education superintendent Kleinkopf was a keen observer of how individuals made use of the environment in which they were thrust. After admiring an artful display of crafts made from the lowly sagebrush, he noted in his diary that, "had Mark Twain been here he might want to re-write his description of the sagebrush. It has been transplanted to many rock gardens around the barracks together with moss, cactus, and desert grass. It adds much to the artistic beauty."³² Kleinkopf admired the internees' abilities as colonists to see a strange environment with new eyes and to recognize the value and usefulness of the new things they encountered.

Located in California's Owens Valley between the towns of Lone Pine and Independence, Manzanar is familiar to those who know the story of the theft of the valley's water to feed Los Angeles's insatiable thirst. It is an arid landscape, in the rain shadow of the Sierra Nevada, but the snowmelt of the mountains provides an ample water supply. Ansel Adams, who photographed the camp in 1943, found grandeur in the site: "I believe that the arid splendor of the desert, ringed with towering mountains, has strengthened the spirit of the people of Manzanar. I do not say all are conscious of this influence, but I am sure most have responded, one way or another, to the resonances of the environment. From the harsh soil they have extracted fine crops; they have made gardens glow in the firebreaks and between barracks."³³

Here too open spaces were appropriated and gardens of all sizes created. Home to the largest group of professional gardeners — nearly 60 percent of the internees were farmers or gardeners — largely from southern California, Manzanar displayed the sophisticated skills of

this community. According to the National Park Service *Cultural Landscape Report*, the gardens “became poignant expressions of an era in Japanese American history when landscape gardening was at its apex as a profession in the United States.”³⁴ The WRA supported garden and park projects and even paid some landscape professionals.

Gardens and lawns, encouraged by the WRA to help control the omnipresent dust, came almost immediately. By August 1942 the lawns were so successful that the camp newspaper, the *Manzanar Free Press*, bemoaned the fact that there was but a single push mower for the entire camp. Internees constructed a reservoir and canal to feed irrigation water to the camp. They collected granite from the Sierra Nevada and large, jagged volcanic rocks from the White Mountains, using the rocks to create hardscape features such as borders, wading pools, and walls. Other found materials were arranged and molded into arbors, clotheslines, barbecue grills, picnic tables, fences, and even garden borders made of tin cans.

Firebreaks between barracks were transformed into community spaces. One firebreak victory garden was subdivided into plots for which families paid membership dues. Nonmembers could work in the garden on a communal basis. Recreational facilities such as baseball diamonds, football fields, a judo building, and a platform for kendo and outdoor theaters also sprang up in the firebreaks. Still standing on the camp’s western edge, Manzanar’s fenced cemetery and its monument has become perhaps the single-most identifiable symbol of the internment camp experience.

Manzanar is Spanish for apple orchard, and on the WRA site were remnants of a farming community that had been abandoned by the 1930s. Internees nurtured and incorporated long-neglected apple and pear trees into their open spaces. Jeanne Wakatsuki Houston remembers moving with her parents “to block 28, right up next to one of the old pear orchards. That’s where we stayed until the end of the war, and these trees stand in my memory for the turning of our life in the camp, from the outrageous to the tolerable.”³⁵

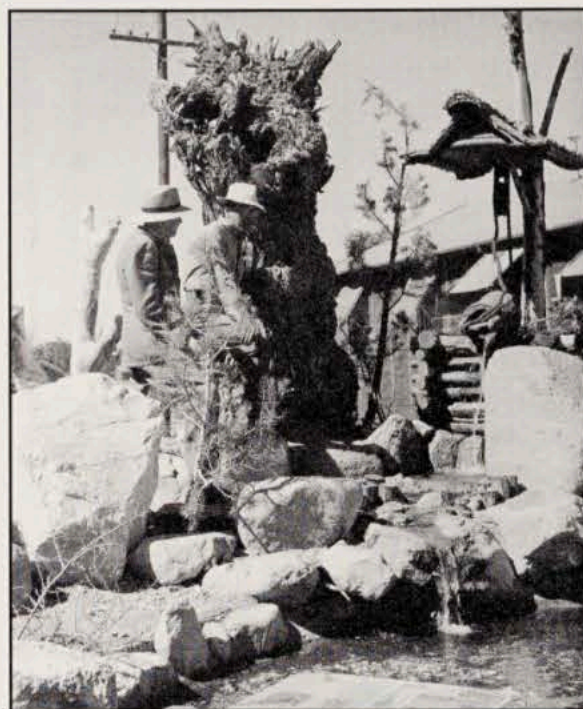
The *Manzanar Free Press* credited William Katsuki, a Bel Air area gardener, with the first ornamental garden at his barracks home in block 24. He began construction in April 1942 (the first evacuees arrived March 21). It included a small pond made of granite from the Sierra Nevada, miniature bridges, and Joshua trees from Death Valley, sixty-five miles to the southeast (the Inyo County newspaper editorialized against such trips while gas rationing was in effect). Many oth-



At Manzanar, Dorothea Lange photographed the victory garden plots, which lay in the vast open spaces between blocks of barracks.

ers soon followed Katuski’s lead, including Tak Moto, whose rock garden in block 15 was the first residential rock garden mentioned in any of the block manager’s daily reports. Houston remembers her father planting succulents and moss and hauling stones from the desert for their doorway garden.

The mess halls became the location for Manzanar’s most elaborate gardens. The garden at the block 22 mess hall has taken on almost legendary status, as have the individuals involved in its creation. Hawaii-born Harry Ueno managed a fruit stand in Los Angeles before the war and was a mess hall cook in block 22. Akira Nishi, along with his brother Kuichiro, owned a San Fernando Valley nursery specializing in roses. In July 1942 Ueno had the idea of building a pond at the mess hall entry so “people can enjoy it while they are waiting for the mess hall bell to ring to line up.” When Ueno and others began digging the hole, Akira Nishi offered to draw up a plan. Many people also joined the effort, which included hauling rocks weighing up to two tons that were destined to be sitting places outside the mess hall. The plan called for twenty-four bags of cement to line the bottom of the pond, but camp policy restricted them to ordering three sacks at a time.



The product of a great deal of coordinated volunteer labor, the mess hall garden at block 22 in Manzanar was a carefully constructed delight for internees waiting to enter the hall for meals. In the center is a tall dead tree trunk.

Internees jokingly referred to the pond as the Three-sack Pond; it was also known as Otaba no Ike, after the source of sacred water at Kyoto's famed Kiyomizu Temple.³⁶

The completed block 22 garden measured over 25 by 110 feet and was encircled by small stones. The centerpiece of the garden was a figure-eight pond with a concrete pathway across its neck. The lower pool had a small island. Large and small stones bordered most of the pond. The water was pumped into a "wishing well" built by George S. Takemura so that it overflowed and tumbled into the pool. These were popular in the first Japanese-style gardens in the nineteenth century in North America. At the north end of the gardens, a ring of stones outlined a tree.

Ultimately, almost every block had its own garden. Landscape contractor Henry Nishi, Kuichiro's son, remembers the block 22 gardens as "nothing really special," but in the fall of 1942 the garden won first prize in a reader's poll in the *Manzanar Free Press's* Best Garden Contest.³⁷ There was great cooperation but also competition among the blocks and builders.

This first and highly visible pond-making effort at block 22 sparked a flurry of garden construction. Ueno thinks that seventeen or eighteen ponds were ultimately built. In August, the block 34 manager

reported that "the men in our block are hard at work on building a fish pond and garden in front of the mess hall."³⁸ At block 15 Roy Suguwara, a former gardener, and Kuichiro, a former flower grower, designed and constructed a pond there. Acquiring cement was still a problem, and block managers' reports note the theft of hundreds of sacks.

Each garden was unique, but gardens outside mess halls and the camp hospital shared common features. Typically there were a rectangular perimeter of small stones framing a watercourse and a shaped pond as the central design feature. Gathered and carefully chosen stones bordered the ponds. Ponds were made more enticing with small islands, bridges, waterfalls, cascades, or fountains. Internees stocked the ponds with carp. Given the camp's dimensions and the standard location in the blocks, most gardens were of similar size and had a north-south orientation. But they were also privy to a common symbolic language derived from Japanese garden tradition.

Manzanar's mess hall garden at block 34, San-shi-en ("3-4 garden"), won second place in the garden competition. It is a Momoyama hill-and-pond-style garden in three levels, with a rise of stones and water source leading to a watercourse flowing into a lower pool. These gardens have their origins in China in Taoist and Buddhist beliefs. The garden is meant to evoke peace, prosperity, pleasantness, and long life. The rock arrangements symbolize the Taoist's "immortal isles"; believed to be islands off the coast of China or Korea, they were thought to be the dwelling places of people (*hsien*) who have the secrets of everlasting youth. Traditionally, the *hsien* traveled throughout the immortal isles on the backs of beautiful cranes, and within these mystic islands all the creatures were white, every flower was fragrant, and all the fruits brought immortality to those who ate them. Originally these were floating isles, but they were then fixed in space on the backs of tortoises.

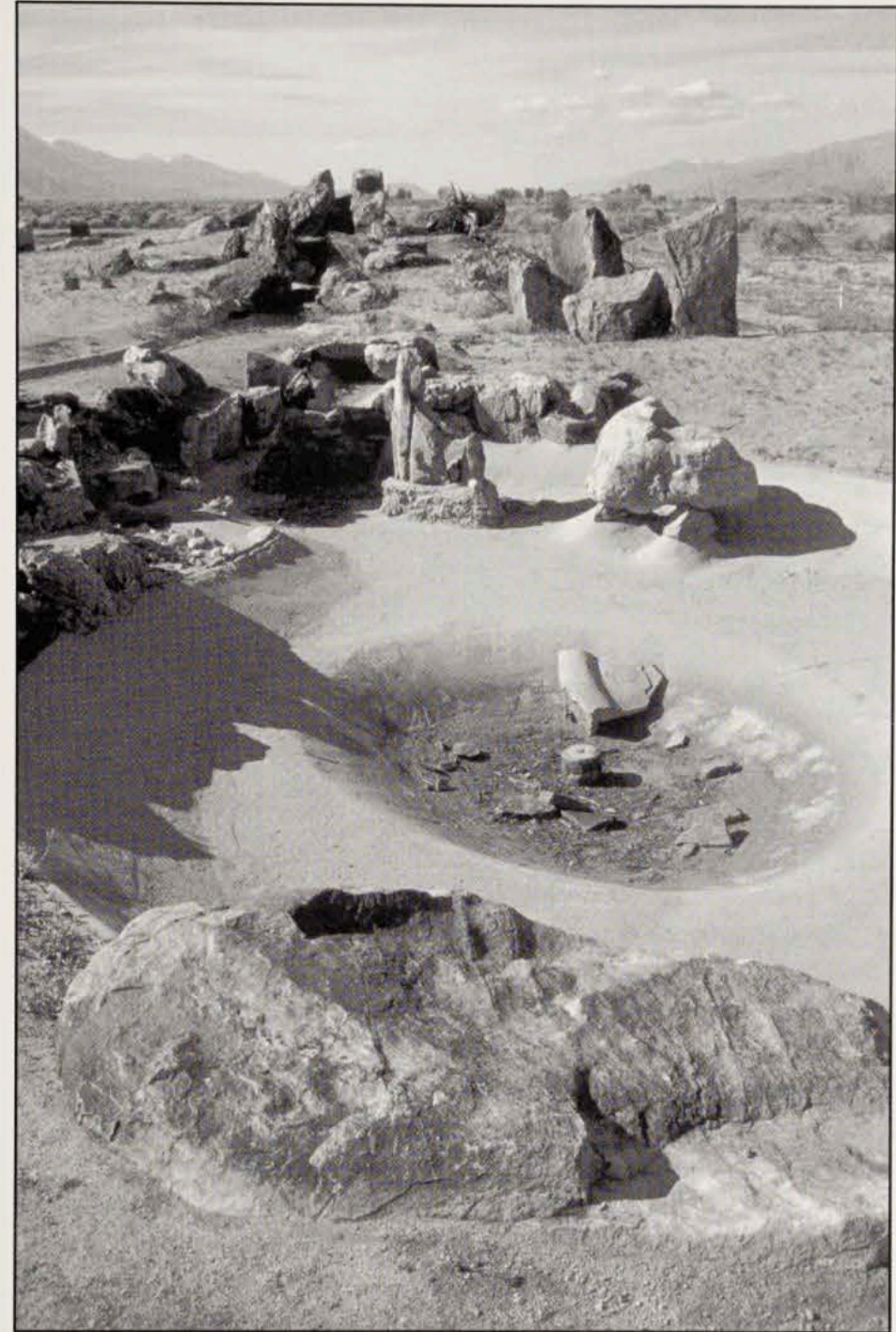
The hill and stones to the north (center middle ground in the photo on p. 185) represent Mount Shumisen, in Buddhism, said to be the highest mountain and the sacred mountain at the center of the universe, where the Buddha is enthroned. The sun, moon, and planets rotate around Mount Shumisen, which supports the heavens and is surrounded by nine mountain ranges and eight seas. The watercourse begins at these stones, following a channel to pools below (foreground). The upright stones symbolize cranes, and there is a large flat turtle rock as well (foreground). Although the forms in the garden

mirror the shapes of animals, they also carry other subtle meanings. The steepness and jaggedness of the crane island combine the three forces often represented in garden compositions, with elements that are horizontal (earth), diagonal (man), and vertical (heaven). Turtle rocks and islands suggest ancient, worn mountains and also offer symbolic protection from natural disasters and proper control of rivers. When found together, crane and turtle (*tsuru-kame*) represent an ageless vitality.

At another level, the block 34 garden is also a miniaturized landscape of the transition from mountains to stream, river valley, and finally plain. As in all the gardens at Manzanar, this transition is visible by lifting one's eyes to the mountains of the Sierra on the western horizon. Japanese gardens use the idea of *shakkei*, or borrowed scenery, and many of Manzanar's gardens capitalize on distant views or even draw the eye toward specific peaks or ranges.

The hospital gardens and parks at Manzanar combined elements of hill and pond gardens with both traditional stroll and tea gardens. A composition of winding paths and pauses leading through a sequence of carefully unfolding pictures, stroll gardens are meant to be seen in progression. The choreographed movement is intended to highlight one's awareness of the garden and its sensory experience. Nitaro ("William") Ogami was hospital grounds foreman and gardener. His son, Arthur, remembers his father spending much of his time working at the hospital: "He would take his crew, and they would furnish trucks and tools, and they would drag them up to the foothills and the mountains. They would pick up rocks, shrubs, trees, whatever he needed to use in the landscaping."³⁹ There were rock circles around trees, planting beds around buildings, pathways, stepping stones, ramps and stairs, retaining walls, and a concrete bench beautifully crafted to simulate wood. Used by both patients and staff, the central elements of the hospital garden were a pond and watercourse over fifty feet long. The water began its journey in a concrete and rock basin, then cascaded along a serpentine channel down over three modest falls into a twenty-foot-long basin that was about five feet lower than the small hill. The length of the stream was marked on both sides by a careful arrangement of stones of varying sizes. Almost midway along the waterway, a path of concrete and stepping zones cut through the garden, allowing a classic view up and down the waterway.

One of several areas at Manzanar transformed into parkland,



The mess hall garden at block 34 at Manzanar expressed Taoist and Buddhist principles and beliefs. The photograph faces north.



Cherry Park was the area next to the children's village, where orphans lived. F. M. Uyematsu of Montebello, California, donated a thousand trees from his prewar nursery stock for the project, but water constraints limited how many of these could be planted. The park included a wisteria trellis over a watercourse, a teahouse, and a lawn. Landscape gardener William Katsuki supervised the project. North Park benefited from a shady grove of cottonwoods that had been part of a ranch on the site. As movement beyond the fences was progressively permitted, two South Parks were also constructed that took advantage of large shade trees and creekside locations. These supplemented a popular picnic area in the camp's southwest corner, where Bairs Creek cut across the camp boundary.

Merritt Park, however, was the site at Manzanar most photographed by visitors, such as Ansel Adams and Dorothea Lange, as well as by camp photographer Toyo Miyatake and the camp staff. Although in theory cameras were not permitted in camp, in practice many photographs were taken. As National Park Service landscape architect Anna Tamura notes, Merritt Park provided "a scenic and photogenic place to mark the passage of major life events, such as birthdays, weddings, and farewells to soldiers. These scenic places allowed internees to celebrate these passages without fear of poisoning a lifetime of these memories with reminders of their imprisonment."⁴⁰

Construction on Merritt Park began in a firebreak in 1942. The camp's showcase garden was first named Rose Park, later renamed Pleasure Park and finally Merritt Park in honor of Ralph Merritt, the relocation camp administrator who was director from late 1942 until Manzanar was dismantled in 1946. Tak Muro supervised construction, but the design is credited to a collective enterprise orchestrated by the Nishi brothers, Akira and Kuichiro. The densely planted one-acre park eventually included ponds with islands, bridges, waterfalls, and a teahouse. The first plantings included domestic roses grafted onto native rootstock by rose expert Kuichiro. The WRA supported the project and even paid the builders between \$16 and \$19 a month for their work.

The design of Merritt Park was an adaptation of a Japanese stroll garden. At the park's entrance were two large upright stele, which internees had harvested from near Yosemite. One stele was inscribed in Japanese: "To the memory of fellow Japanese immigrants . . . [who, although ushered to] this place with the breaking of friendly relations



Merritt Park at Manzanar included this pool and bridge, shown here in 1943.

between the two countries, have come to enjoy this quiet, peaceful place." The park was dedicated "for the enjoyment of the people and to the memory of the time of our residence here."⁴¹ A pond was fed by water that cascaded over a turtle-shaped rock dividing the water into two waterfalls. Another stone was placed to suggest a turtle swimming in the pond. The park offered a fine display of craftsmanship in the park's benches, bridges, and rock arrangements. The rustic teahouse was constructed from natural materials. Tree stumps roped together marked the area of the teahouse and the path.

Henry Nishi thought of his father's garden work that "it was just something he liked to do. Something he loved to do. Something for the betterment of the camp." Reflecting on the paradox that Merritt Park represented, Jeanne Wakatsuki Houston wrote, "sometimes in



Kuichiro Nishi (right) helps as a fellow internee uses Manzanar's only mower to groom the lawn in Merritt Park, 1943.

the evenings you could walk down the raked gravel paths. You could face away from the barracks, look past a tiny rapids toward the darkening mountains, and for a while not be a prisoner at all. You could hang suspended in some odd, almost lovely land you could not escape from yet almost didn't want to leave."⁴²

As artistic and cultural expressions, the internment camp gardens were rich in meaning. They combined aspects of classic Japanese garden practice, the Japanese American garden traditions that had evolved in the prewar West Coast, with responses to the conditions at each camp. Gardens are always adaptations to specific environments. At Manzanar and all the camps, a language of design that had developed in another landscape was both constrained and liberated by the necessity to employ local plants and rocks. These were gardens in a desert landscape unlike the more Mediterranean environment of Los Angeles or the fecund greenery of Puget Sound, and certainly in a more arid landscape than anything in Japan. In most cases

ample water was supplied by irrigation from systems largely built by the internees. Thus, the gardens had an affinity to oasis gardens found in desert landscapes throughout the world. They presented a dramatic contrast to their surroundings and a respite from extreme conditions.

Garden making in the camps was the domestication of an inhospitable environment. Camps were "home," but only for an indeterminate period. Internees worked to create a cultural setting that fostered a semblance of normalcy under abnormal and unjust conditions. Gardens offered the dignity of work, opportunities for the expression of individual creativity, and a shared cultural identity. The beauty of the gardens offered solace and a contrast with an alien environment. However admirable and beautiful these creations, the frame delineates and completes the picture. The "wall" for all of these gardens was a barbed-wire fence with guard towers, their searchlights and guns pointed inward — as we have seen for ghetto residents, POWs, and civilian internees. All of these gardens, grand and small, were acts of resistance, directed toward the maintenance of cultural integrity and self-respect. They were tangible symbols of hope that helped people survive their internment, fostered their mental and physical health, and were a demonstration of psychological and also political defiance. The gardens further offered an assertion of cultural identity that contrasted dramatically with the conditions of internment and the withholding of basic American freedoms. In a sense the gardens were the anticamp, a subversive response to internment, where individual and collective gestures were a way of denying the camp administration and environment. Like George Eisen's protective cloak (see chapter 3), they are part of the struggle to transform "camp" into something else.

As with the other gardens we have examined, gardens constructed by Japanese American internees also fulfilled more prosaic garden functions. They were the sites for growing plants for food and pleasure; they were places to sit, gather, work, and play. They were places that ameliorated the extremes of climate through the making of an amenable microclimate. Plantings and structures offered comfort and shade and relief from the heat and dust. Interned at Crystal City, a Justice Department internment camp in south Texas, the Reverend Kenko Yamashita, a Soto Zen bishop who came to the United States

in 1938, said, "Japanese farmers couldn't sit and just watch it [the barren soil], so they put gardens in front of their houses. They grew eggplants and cucumbers; so sometimes we had fresh cucumbers."⁴³ Gardens have deep meanings, but they are also about the simple and equally profound pleasure of a fresh cucumber.

Internees' desire to connect to a more familiar nature was powerful. Arthur Kleinkopf was impressed by three Japanese ladies who he drove out of camp one day in October 1942. It was their first trip out of Minidoka in six months. "They were thrilled beyond words by the sight of trees, flowers, and green fields. One lady said, 'Mr. Kleinkopf, I'd just like to get out of the car, walk over to one of those trees, touch it, and put my arms around it.' A lump came into my throat as I tried, somewhat unsuccessfully, I'm sure, to understand, because only those who have experienced the sufferings and longings of a minority group whose members have been evacuated from their homes and all that home holds dear, can ever fully understand the feelings of the lady who wanted to caress the tree."⁴⁴

Gardens provide a way to domesticate space. Evacuees took the empty WRA framework and filled it to make it into their homes, the domestic environment where personal and family lives were enacted. Control over one's environment is not just over space; it also implies the ability to control one's social and psychological environment. Garden making (and other forms of construction in the camps) was a way of taking possession through labor, design, creativity, use, and cultural signification. For people who had just been dispossessed of their homes, belongings, careers, and daily lives, this was particularly important. The tangible physical result was a form of communication — we did this, and this is who we are.

Gardens are capable of carrying a wide range of meaning. The actions of the garden makers imposed an order on the camps that was theirs, not the WRA's. The gardens were beautiful but also an expression of anti-institutionalization. In a dehumanized and alien setting, internees humanized the camps by introducing familiar garden features. The practice began at the assembly center, where people were dehumanized immediately by being confined to places made for — and recently populated by — animals. Although internees had little opportunity to bring personal property with them, they could possess



Residents of this barracks at Manzanar pose at the entrance garden.

the gardens. Because size was not critical, the smallest space could be appropriated: residential barracks gardens ranged from only two by four feet to as large as twenty by forty.

The gardens were part of homemaking, and the meaning and expression of "home" was different for each of the resident generations. For the Issei, it was a memory, often of childhood homes in Japan as well as the homes they had made in America. For Nisei, it was an imagined and idealized cultural home in Japan as well as their American homes, which often had gardens in a Japanese style. For Kibei it was homes in both places. All the gardens were a combination of Japanese cultural heritage and American experience set primarily in the landscape of the American West. The gardens were signs of normalcy and "mementos of home" for the residents, people *Newsweek* described as not only transferred but also "transplanted."⁴⁵

Henry Nishi reports that at Manzanar, people had more time to study and to transmit Japanese traditions, such as garden making.

According to WRA policy, all meetings and publications at the camps had to be in English, and Japanese was spoken only in the privacy of the barracks. This undermined whatever sense of “home” internees might have been able to imagine in the camps. Under such conditions, garden making allowed internees to make very public statements using the garden language of their culture.

Domestication also implies a calming or quelling of something wild. Plunked down in rudimentary buildings surrounded by an alien wilderness, internees were understandably stressed by the sudden change and by the environment. Kleinkopf perceptively noted that “the impact of the emotional disturbances as a result of the evacuation procedures, plus the dull dreary existence in a desert region surely must give these people a feeling of helplessness, hopelessness, and despair which we on the outside do not and will never fully understand.”⁴⁶ The gardens played a role in relieving the stress of camp life by acting as mental oases. Although the internees were not combatants in the war, like POWs they too needed to sustain their morale. The government supported this homemaking for its own reasons: first, the WRA preferred an active, occupied population; second, it took a paradoxical pride in camp beautification, as we already saw POW and civilian camp commandants do in Germany and Asia during World War II.

Garden making also allowed internees to identify with the historic western experience. The camps were essentially frontier communities in wild landscapes, which internees “civilized” with their frontier gardens. The first issue of the *Minidoka Irrigator* (note that irrigation is an instrument of landscape domestication and transformation) editorialized:

Minidoka, as we know it now, is a vast stretch of sagebrush stubble and shifting, swirling sand — a dreary forbidding, flat expanse of arid wilderness. Minidoka in September of 1942 is the sort of place people would normally traverse only to get to another destination. We are not here by choice. We, the ten thousand, then, can have but one resolve; to apply our combined energies and efforts to the grim task of conquering the elements and converting a wasteland into an inhabitable community. Our obligation to ourselves is to wrest the nearest approximation of normalcy of an abnormal situation. Our goal is the creation of an oasis. Our great adventure is a repetition of the frontier struggle of pioneers against the land and the elements.



Tomo Akiyama, an Issei dye works operator from Seattle, built this garden at Minidoka.

Minidoka internees seemed ready to take this to heart. The Reverend Taro Gato combined the complexities of both spiritual and patriotic sentiment in this statement from the *Topaz Times*: “Topaz is more than just an engineering marvel. It is more than just an isolated settlement for evacuees. It is the sum total of dreams, deep thinking, courage, and faith — it is a living personality. Topaz is born of the great Mother America. We are again the pioneers, blazing the road into the wilderness of our social frontiers. Not that we alone march, but that we follow the ever guiding pillar of the divine wisdom and light — it is our strength.”⁴⁷ The task was clear to the internees at all the camps: make this a “home” in the way the pioneers domesticated the American West in the past century.

In a depersonalized institutional environment, the ability to personalize one’s environment assumes a larger importance, as houses and gardens, generally symbols of self, also become tools of community expression. The picture was typical of people moving into a new community, where individual actions are ways of both personalizing one’s territory and simultaneously making an offering to the community. When forty-eight-year-old Tomo Akiyama, a dye works operator from Seattle, was asked why he made his Minidoka garden even though it was not a permanent home, his answer was recorded in Robert Hosokawa’s garden report: “This was a means of bettering the quality of life during that interim, no matter how short or long. It gave pleasure to his spare moments and made life more livable. At the same time it contributed to the community as a whole.”⁴⁸



Gardens are the product of labor, but garden work generally represents the more pleasurable aspects of labor. The satisfaction of creating something out of raw materials recurs at each stage of garden making, from conception through harvest. Even unskilled gardeners feel a sense of control over their materials and a sense of satisfaction as they monitor the progress of their planting or a construction project as it develops.

The Japanese American community was used to hard work. Keeping busy and active was a way of maintaining self-respect, and pride in one's work was important. Imprisoned at Poston, Hanayo Inouye said, "We were Japanese after all . . . so no one spent lazy days. Some people planted various kinds of trees in the compound, and between the trees we grew vegetables and other things."⁴⁹

Arthur Ogami, the son of Nitaro Ogami, the creator of Manzanar's hospital gardens, emphasized that garden building kept people busy with something useful and productive, which he thought was especially important for the Issei. He added that garden making was also "just a natural thing to be doing. When you have the manpower and people to do it. For their own pleasure, for the camp itself. They took a lot of pride in whatever they were doing."⁵⁰

Arthur Kleinkopf admired the variety of tin vessels that were used as sprinklers. "I watched one Japanese man sprinkle his garden. He had a two-quart can with nail holes in the bottom. Near the top on one side was a hole about an inch in diameter and another hole on the opposite side of the same size but slightly lower so that when a 3-foot stick was run through the holes, the can made a good dipper and sprinkler combined."⁵¹ The internees responded to necessity and deprivation with an improvisatory sensibility toward materials.

Gardens are an outlet for creativity and artistry. Perhaps the recognition of beauty and the human desire to create things and places of beauty are heightened by ugly conditions. Almost as if it were a reflex, beautification of their surroundings began immediately at the assembly centers. At Tanforan Yoshiko Uchida said, "We all worked constantly to make the windswept racetrack a more attractive and pleasant place." He noted that what had been a junk pile was transformed into a colorful garden, and he admired the park created in the race-track's infield: "It wasn't much, but it was one of many efforts made to comfort the eye and heart." Uchida is clear about the connection



between "the eye," or the perception of beauty, and "the heart," or the sense of well-being, even health, that beauty can impart. These creations were good for both the soul and sight.⁵²

Camp residents were aware of the contribution beauty made to their lives. The *Gila News-Courier* praised WRA regional director E. R. Fryer's attention to camp beautification: "It is evident that people living under the physical drawbacks of the centers need the stimulation of environmental order and beauty to help them in the difficulties they are encountering." The administration seemed aware that beauty was essential for people's morale and of "inestimable, though intangible, value." The *Topaz Times* was particularly generous in praising the role of women:

Though Nature wasn't generous with Topaz in giving out her verdant gifts, the women here have combated the ugliness and drabness of the surroundings by directing their creative impulses towards the beautification of the home. . . . Artificial flowers fashioned from crepe and wax paper, and crocheting thread, with its vibrant color and personality, enhance the rooms of any apartment. But flowers contrived by art is an inferior substitute for the genuine blooms. We, who have lived near the rolling green hills of California with its lush poppies and wild plants, the scented gardens, immaculate lawns and thriving flower beds of the bay area, yearn for Nature's expression of greenery. Happily, though on a small scale, we can induce greenery to grow near the windows of our barracks.⁵³

Although many internees could no longer practice their occupations, artists were very active in the camps as practitioners and teachers. Artists have a keen eye for recognizing the qualities of their surroundings, and in the camps they captured the sublime vistas and dramatic grandeur to offer solace or to comment wryly on their condition. But all the internees, not just the artists, could glean something from the observation of nature. Machiye Maxine Nakamura, for example, noticed: "A saguaro bloomed this spring, that queen of the desert, thriving stately where no nourishment is visible. It had this message to me that even in this seared land many things will bloom. One must stand above the saguaro to see its beauty, so I, too, must climb beyond the present difficulties, and search for that possible beauty that may come out of this thorny existence here."⁵⁴

While the conditions in camps were not the horrendous landscapes of battlefield trenches, the artistry in the internment camps has affinities with the trench art of the war. Both were expressions of

art where it was least expected, and its creation brought solace to its creators and a sense of surprise and wonder to those who viewed it.

In his poem “Children of Camp,” Lawson Fusao Inada, who was at camps in Arkansas and Colorado, expresses the paradox. In a place of incarceration, stripped of poetry and joy, people still made poetry, art, and gardens.

The people made poetry
With their very own hands —
Little gifts of scrap
For precious loved ones,
Friends, elders, children.

There was no poetry in camp.
But the people made it so.
With hands, vision, hearts,
The people made it so.⁵⁵

Art, in all its forms, visual, musical, literary, was not a luxury or a frill, but an imperative and perhaps even a necessity. At Heart Mountain, when Shoji Nagumo “thought about children being raised in the desert without grass or trees,” he “was sure they would become human beings who would not feel joy or pleasure in anything. They might even grow up not understanding the beauty of nature.”⁵⁶ This concern encouraged him to work to beautify the camp and to organize the camp’s victory garden.

How was it possible for Japanese Americans to maintain a sense of cultural identity and self-respect in the face of imprisonment and vilification by their adopted — or native — country? At Tule Lake, Hiroshi Kashiwagi felt that “in addition to the physical confinement, there was [a] fence around our spirit, and this imprisonment of the spirit was the most ravaging part of the evacuation experience.”⁵⁷ Under camp conditions, certain underlying traits and behaviors came to the fore. Strategies of resistance and survival, both conscious and unconscious, merged; complementary Japanese cultural attitudes fostered the internees’ adjustment to conditions while simultaneously working to subvert the intentions of the government. *Shikata ga nai* — it cannot be helped — is an acceptance of fate and situations that allowed people to deal with the situation. At the same time the internees displayed *gaman*, which connotes perseverance, fortitude,



Minidoka residents tend the block 26 garden.

or stamina. These traits were coupled with a tradition of working together as a community.

In the camps, cultural identity could be reinforced not only through shared underlying values but also in cultural practices that united individuals from disparate communities in both Japan and the United States. Japan has a venerated tradition of garden art honed over many centuries. That expertise and history of appreciation accompanied immigrants to North America. The gardens “made familiar the strange land” of the camps by continuing a cultural legacy. Garden making was a way for Japanese immigrants to assert their heritage while also adjusting to American culture. In the camps, traditional Japanese garden elements were integrated into miniature front yards, Japanese vegetables were planted in victory gardens — and there were many more baseball fields than judo rings. This was a continuation of a process that began with the first immigrants from Japan. As art historian Kendall Brown has noted, “By grafting part of their cultural heritage to their new home in the form of gardens, these Issei put down literal and figurative roots. By creating something Japanese in America, they made themselves into Japanese Americans.”⁵⁸

In the prewar Little Tokyos of the West Coast, certain institutions were de facto community centers. The Maneki restaurant in Seattle’s international district was such a place; the restaurant garden was a

sanctuary where people could be themselves. Paradoxically, in the camps — which were also ethnic ghettos — this was possible, as well. There was a continuity of the social functions of gardens and parks, and in the camps these were the venues for traditional cultural activities such as ceremonies, weddings, and festivals. According to Tama Keiki Tochiwara, who has studied the Issei gardens of Seattle, the gardens were simultaneously cultural sanctuaries and an adaptation to a new setting.⁵⁹

At the 1979 pilgrimage to Tule Lake, Richard Oyama read his “Poem for the Survivors of Tule Lake,” which includes the lines, “And so you survived, / And thrived, to raise / A garden from / A desert land.”⁶⁰

Although the phrase *spiritual resistance* is often applied to the European ghettos of World War II, it holds true for Japanese American internment camps as well. The quality of *gaman* is akin to resistance. One can even perceive a certain stubbornness in camp behavior. Thrust into this unbearable and ugly situation, the internees not only withstood it but did so with honor and transformed what was ugly into something beautiful. With much pride, Uchida found that people at Topaz “endured the hardship of the evacuation with dignity, stoic composure, disciplined patience, and an amazing resilience of spirit. I think they displayed a level of strength, grace, and courage that is truly remarkable.”⁶¹

Camp garden makers resisted their incarceration in many ways. Their first act was to appropriate land without permission. After having been stripped of their own land and possessions, they now staked a claim to their new surroundings. When negotiations with the WRA for permissions were unsuccessful, they sometimes ignored the regulations. Internees transformed scrounged and gathered materials into art as they constructed gardens within the confines of the camp. This was the anticamp, where acts of cultural identity could be construed as subversive to those in power. Arthur Ogami reflected that “the gardens expresses that just because we’re here, we have to do something to refresh our feelings. I think that the gardens is something that they want to express that there is hope for peace and freedom. And you can go to these gardens and feel it.”⁶²

Jeanne Wakatsuki Houston saw her father emasculated by his new circumstance, but most coped and even defied authorities, sometimes drawing strength and solace from the inhospitable but powerful landscape around them. The view to the mountains was important, especially for the Issei. Houston observed that Mount Whitney, which was visible from Manzanar,

reminded Papa of Fujiyama, that is, it gave him the same kind of spiritual sustenance. The tremendous beauty of those peaks was inspirational, as so many natural forms are to the Japanese (the rocks outside our doorway could be those mountains in miniature). They also represented those forces in nature, those powerful and inevitable forces that cannot be resisted, reminding man that sometimes he must simply endure that which cannot be changed. . . . What had to be endured was the climate, the confinement, the steady crumbling away of family life. But the camp itself had been made livable.⁶³

The resilience of plants was mirrored in the fortitude and determination of the population. When Toyo Suyemoto complained to his mother about camp life, she replied, “‘Spring will come again.’ I burst out, ‘But it won’t be the same spring!’ ‘No,’ she continued, ‘not the same spring, but another spring, a new spring.’” On the train en route to Manzanar, Yoriyuki Kikuchi identified with the geraniums he noticed on the side of the Los Angeles River, later writing a poem recalling the experience: “Uprooted, thrown in a pile, side of the road. / But remember, rise again and full bloom once again.”⁶⁴ Internees were evoking images of oppression, defiance, and survival similar to those used by Jewish ghetto residents in Europe in the same war.

The growth of gardens was echoed in the life of camp residents. In Tim Toyama’s play *Independence Day* (later filmed as *Day of Independence*), which takes place during a baseball game played in a camp on July 4, Zip, a teenage Nisei, receives a letter from his Issei father, who has returned to Japan. The letter includes a poem from his father, where he likens his son to a pine tree growing in the garden.

In the desert, a garden,

Alive.

Spring has come again.

In the garden in the desert

A stream,

Water from winter’s melted snow,

I put my hand in the flowing water,

And feel winter’s melted tears between my fingers.

In the garden in the desert,

A young pine tree grows.

My son.⁶⁵



In Shinto tradition, the landscape is filled with spirits called *kami* who inhabit elements of the natural world. Stones are particularly important vessels for *kami*. Jeanne Wakatsuki Houston thought that the rock gardens would outlive the barracks, roads, and towers of Manzanar, and that the camp's enduring physical legacy would be its stone gardens. Because she saw "each stone . . . [as] a mouth, speaking for a family, for some man who had beautified his doorstep," she found such stone gardens "enduringly human." In Houston's short story "Rock Garden," Old Man Morita befriends a young girl, Reiko, at Manzanar. He teaches her to meditate and takes her to what she immediately understands to be a special place, a garden hidden behind a bamboo with a "brilliant white lake of tiny pebbles." The old man teaches her "Rock, water, plant, wood all same. You, me, rock same." Here Reiko learns to rake the pebbles and help him "garden his rocks."⁶⁶